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The Unsurpassed Surgeon

Amerikave Indavamsa

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It may come as a surprise to many meditators to learn that the Buddha did not make use of meditation centers or meditation retreats to help his disciples attain the fruits of his teachings such as stream entry, once-returner, non-returner and arahantship. The Buddha is not found in the suttas to say to his disciples, “These are meditation halls, these are meditation cells. Meditate, O bhikkhus, do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is our instruction to you.” Rather, he is found in the suttas to say: “These are the foot of trees, O bhikkhus, these are empty huts. Meditate, O bhikkhus, do not be negligent, lest you regret it later. This is our instruction to you.”

Some have confused monasteries in the Buddha’s time such as the Jetavana Grove, Anathapindhika’s Park or the Mansion of Migara’s Mother to have been meditation centers. But these were the residence of the order of bhikkhus with an assembly hall for carrying out dhamma related functions, including ordinations, dhamma talks and dhamma discussions. As instructed by the Buddha, the bhikkhus and bhikkhunis would find roots of trees and empty huts in nearby forests and dwell there for their day’s meditation. They would then return to the monastery to hear dhamma talks or have dhamma discussions.

Not only are there no records in the suttas of group meditation instructions from the Buddha, but silent meditation retreat without discussions on the dhamma among the participants is highly criticized by the Buddha in the Vinaya Khandaka (mahāvagga 4, pavarana) as follows:

Then the Auspicious One said this to those bhikkhus: “But in what way, O bhikkhus, united and happily together,

without disputing, spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not fatigued on account of almsfood?”

Here, O Bhante, many of us bhikkhus, friends and associates, accepted a certain residence in the Kosalan country for the rains retreat. It occurred to us, O Bhante: “By what means might we united and happily together, without disputing, spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not fatigued on account of almsfood?”

Then it occurred to us, O Bhante: “If we neither speak nor converse with one another, [and would have] the one who returns from village alms gathering first set out the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, set out the drinking water and the rinsing water. The one who returns from village alms gathering last, if there is any food left over, may eat it if he so desires. If he does not desire, he would throw it away where there is little plant life or in water where there are no living beings. He would pack up the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, he would set in order the drinking water and the rinsing water, he would sweep up the refactory. Whoever sees the drinking water vessel, the rinsing water vessel or the toilet water vessel empty and void, would refill it. If it would not be possible for him, then having invited another with the wave of hands, they would fill it by joining hands together, but not on that account should they break into speech. In this way, united and happily together, without disputing, we will spent a comfortable rains retreat, and not fatigued on account of almsfood?”

“So then, O Bhante, we neither spoke nor conversed with one another. The one who returned from village alms gathering first set out the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, set out the drinking water and the rinsing water. The one who returned from village alms gathering last, if there were any food left over, would eat it if he so desired. If he did not desire, he threw it away where there was little plant life or in water where there were no living beings. He packed up the seats, the foot-washing water, the foot stool, the foot-washing wooden

block, the bowl for left-overs having washed it, he set in order the drinking water and the rinsing water, he swept up the refactory. Whoever saw the drinking water vessel, the rinsing water vessel or the toilet water vessel empty and void, refilled it. If it were not possible for him, then having invited another with the wave of hands, they filled it by joining hands together, but not on that account did they break into speech. It is in this way, O Bhante, that united and happily together, without disputing, we will spend a comfortable rains retreat, and not fatigued on account of almsfood?”

Then the Auspicious One addressed the bhikkhus: “Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having spent an uncomfortable [rains retreat], presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like beasts, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like sheep, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. Indeed these empty men, O bhikkhus, simply having lived together like enemies, presume to have spent an equally comfortable [rains retreat]. For how indeed, O bhikkhus, could these empty men, undertake the practice of followers of other standpoints, the observance of silence? This, O bhikkhus, neither [inspires] confidence in those with little confidence, nor increase the confidence of those with confidence. Rather, this only diminish the confidence of those with little confidence and cause wavering in some of those with confidence.” Then the Auspicious One, having reprimanded those bhikkhus in various ways with Dhamma talk, addressed the bhikkhus: (or how many) the bhikkhus address: The practice of followers of other standpoints, O bhikkhus, the observance of silence is not to be undertaken. Whoever would undertake it incurs an offence of wrong-doing. I allow you, O bhikkhus, to invite the bhikkhus you live with during the rains retreat [for feedback] on three grounds, what is seen, heard or suspected. That for you will be a state suitable for communication, a state allowing for rehabilitation from offences, a state honoring the vinaya.

–Vi Kd 4

So why didn't the Buddha adopt silent group meditation as a means of instructing his disciples as was commonly done by other teachers of the Buddha's time?

In this vinaya incidence, the Buddha explains that it is because "It is not, for pleasing those who are not (yet) pleased, nor for increasing (the confidence of) those who are pleased, but it is for displeasing those who are not (yet) pleased as well as those who are pleased, and for causing wavering in some."

But in the *sanganikārāma sutta* (AN 6.68), the Buddha identifies delight in such group retreats as an impediment to making the breakthrough to the four noble truths as follows:

"Indeed, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhus who delight in company, who are delighted with company, who are devoted to delight in company, who delight in a group, who are delighted with a group, who are devoted to delight in a group, will find pleasure while alone in seclusion," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not delighting in seclusion while alone will grasp the sign of the mind," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not grasping the sign of the mind will fulfill right view," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having fulfilled right view will fulfill right samadhi," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having fulfilled right samadhi will abandon the fetters," this possibility is not to be found. "That one not having abandon the fetters will realize nibbana," this possibility is not to be found.

"Indeed, O bhikkhus, that bhikkhus who do not delight in company, who are not delighted with company, who are not devoted to delight in company, who do not delight in a group, who are not delighted with a group, who are not devoted to delight in a group, will find pleasure while alone in seclusion," this possibility is to be found. "That one delighting in seclusion while alone will grasp the sign of the mind," this possibility is to be found. "That one grasping the sign of the mind will fulfill right view," this possibility is to be found. "That one having fulfilled right view will fulfill right samadhi," this possibility is to be found. "That one having fulfilled right samadhi will abandon the fetters,"

this possibility is to be found. “That one having abandon the fetters will realize nibbana,” this possibility is to be found.

–AN 6.68

In the suttas, the Buddha also compares the guided meditation that is currently popular at meditation retreats to how a blind person guides other blind persons as illustrated in the tevijja sutta (DN 13):

Thus apparently, O Vasettha, among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma.

Apparently, even the ancient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeating what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: Attaka, Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, even they do not speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].” Surely those triple-knowledge brahmins who speak thus: “We teach the path to union with that which we do not know, to that which we do not see, this is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to liberation, which practicing accordingly, leads to union with Brahma.”

“So what do you think, O Vasettha, that being so, doesn’t the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar?”

“Certainly, O Bhante, that being so, the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar.”

Good Vasettha. Indeed O Vasettha, that those triple-knowledge

brahmins [could] teach a path to union with that which they do not know, that which they do not see, [claiming]: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to liberation, which practicing accordingly, leads to union with Brahma,” this possibility is not to be found. Just as, O Vasettha, a line of blind men go on in succession holding on to each other, the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. So too, O Vasettha, the statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins seem to me like a line of blind men; the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. These statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be mere speech, turn out to be mere words, turn out to be simply empty, turn out to be simply hollow.

–DN 13

The preferred method of the Buddhas is not to guide the blind but to cure the blind from their blindness so they can walk the path on their own without guidance. Thus, they describe the path they have awakened to as cakkhukaraṇī, maker of eyes, a teaching that gives vision. They also recite this joyous utterance when they awaken this Dhamma-eye as “the eye arose, knowledge arose, wisdom arose, noble knowledge arose, light arose,” as in the dhammacakkappavattana sutta (SN 56.11). What this eye sees is described in that sutta as follows:

imasamiñca pana veyyākaraṇasmim bhaññamāne āyasmato koṇḍaññaassa virajaṃ vītamalaṃ dhammacakkhuṃ udapādi: yaṃ kiñci samudayadhammaṃ sabbantaṃ nirodhadhammanti.

And while this explanation was being spoken, there arose in the venerable Koṇḍañña the pure and spotless Dhamma-eye: “Whatever is liable to origination, all that is liable to cessation.”

–SN 56.11

The Buddha refers to himself in the brahmana sutta (IT 100) as the unsurpassed surgeon whose surgery gives this vision, which he describes as the dhamma offering:

This indeed was said by the Auspicious One, said by the Arahant, as heard by me.

I, O bhikkhus, am a brahmin, ever devoted to [granting] requests, open handed, bearer of my last body, the unsurpassed doctor and surgeon. You are my own sons, born from my mouth, born from the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, heirs to the Dhamma, not heirs in material things.

There are these two givings, O bhikkhus, the giving of material things and the giving of the Dhamma. Of these two givings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the giving of the Dhamma.

There are these two sharings, O bhikkhus, the sharing of material things and the sharing of the Dhamma. Of these two sharings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the sharing of the Dhamma.

There are these two assistances, O bhikkhus, the assistance with material things and the assistance with the Dhamma. Of these two assistances, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the assistance with the Dhamma.

There are these two offerings, O bhikkhus, the offering of material things and the offering of the Dhamma. Of these two offerings, O bhikkhus, this is the foremost, namely, the offering of the Dhamma.

This is the meaning of what the Auspicious One said. Thus, this was said there:

The one free from miserliness who offered the
Dhamma offering,
the Tathagata, compassionate to all beings;
beings venerate the one who has crossed over
being,
that such-like one, best among devas and humans.

“This too is the meaning of what was said by the Auspicious One. Thus was heard by me.”

–IT 100

Those who acquire the Dhamma-eye and become cured from their

blindness are rightly called “children of the Buddha, born from his mouth, born of the Dhamma, created by the Dhamma, heirs to the Dhamma, not heirs in material things.” In other words, the Buddha’s method of guiding his disciples is to teach them the dhamma in order for them to gain the dhamma cakkhu or Dhamma-eye so they can practice in accordance with the dhamma themselves without needing to rely on anyone else, including the Buddha. The Buddha compares this method to a surgeon operating on the eye of a blind man to give him vision so he can walk on his own without being guided by others as described in the magandhiya sutta (MN 75):

Just as, O Māgandiya, a man blind from birth, who cannot see black or white forms, cannot see blue forms, cannot see yellow forms, cannot see red forms, cannot see crimson forms, cannot see the even and uneven, cannot see the stars, cannot see the moon and sun, he might hear one possessed of eyes saying: “Flawless indeed, sir, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean. He would walk in search of a white [cloth]. To him another man might cheat with a coarse robe stained with oil [saying]: Here for you good man, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean. He would accept it. Having accepted it, he would wrap himself with it. Having wrapped himself with it, contented, he would utter these words of contentment: “Flawless indeed, sir, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean.”

For him, his friends and colleagues, blood relations, might hire a physician, a surgeon. That physician or surgeon might make medicine: up-going purgatives, down-going purgatives, ointments, counter-ointments and nasal medicine. So owing to that medicine, his eyes would arise, his eyes would be purified.

For him, along with the arising of his eyes, his lustful desire in that coarse robe stained with oil gets abandoned, and he might also burn with unfriendliness towards that man. Rather, he might even burn with adversity thinking he should be deprived of life [thus:] Indeed for a long time sir, I have been cheated, deceived, tricked in this way by that man with a coarse robe stained with oil [saying:] Here for you good man, is a white cloth, beautiful, spotless and clean.

“It is just so, O Magandiya, even [if] I would to teach the Dhamma for you [thus]: This is that freedom from diseases, this is that nibbana. That you may know that freedom from diseases, you may see that nibbana. Along with the arising of the [dhamma] eye, your lustful desire for the five appropriable khandhas gets abandoned, and it will occur to you thus: Indeed for a long time sir, I have been cheated, deceived, tricked in this way by this mind. Indeed I only undertook form when undertaking, only undertook feeling when undertaking, only undertook perception when undertaking, only undertook sankharas when undertaking, only undertook consciousness when undertaking.

For me in dependence on undertaking, there is being; in dependence on being, there is birth; in dependence on birth, old age and death, sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair arise. Just so, is the arising of this entire amassment of suffering.”

“I have confidence for the master Gotama thus, the venerable Gotama is able to teach me the dhamma in such a way that I might rise from my seat without blindness.”

Well then you, O Magandiya, should associate with true men. Since you, O Magandiya will associate with true men, therefore you, O Magandiya, will hear the true Dhamma. Since you, O Magandiya, will hear the true Dhamma, therefore you, O Magandiya, will practice the Dhamma in accordance with the Dhamma. Since you, O Magandiya, will practice the Dhamma in accordance with the Dhamma, therefore you, O Magandiya, will come to know just by yourself, come to see by yourself: These are diseases, tumors and darts. Here, diseases, tumors and darts cease without remainder.

For me from the cessation of undertaking, there is the cessation of being; from the cessation of being, there is the cessation of birth; from the cessation of birth, old age and death, sorrow, lamentation, physical suffering, mental suffering and despair cease. Just so, is the cessation of this entire stock of suffering.”

—MN 75

The key words in the Buddhas method is to teach the true Dhamma for his disciples to give rise to the Dhamma-eye for them to come to know just by themselves, to come to see just by themselves suffering and its cessation.

In the mahātanhasankhāyika sutta (MN 38), after questioning the bhikkhus on their ability to see paṭiccasamuppāda for themselves with the Dhamma-eye, the Buddha asks them:

Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you say:
“We respect the Teacher. It is just out of respect for the Teacher that we speak thus.”

Certainly not, Bhante.

Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you say:
“The samana has said thus to us. We speak thus, on account of just what the samana has said.”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you acknowledge another Teacher?”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Knowing thus, O bhikkhus, seeing thus, would you return to the practices, debates and auspicious ceremonies of common samanas and brahmanas, taking them as the essence?”

Certainly not, Bhante.

“Are you not, O bhikkhus, only saying that which you have known by yourselves, seen by yourselves, understood by yourselves?”

Yes, Bhante.

–MN 38

Nowadays many meditation masters claim to teach the path to nibbana as taught by the Buddha, similar to how the brahmins trained in the three vedas claimed to teach the path to union with Brahma. But many of them teach based on interpretations of the Buddha’s teaching that does not come from the Buddha. Some may say there is no need to worry because these elders are meditation masters who

teach the doctrine of the elders as handed down from teacher to pupil, but all one needs to do is to look at the very first sutta chanted at the first council by the venerable Ananda called the Brahmajālā sutta (DN 1), where the Buddha gives accounts of many meditation masters, some able to recall their past lives and some even able to attain the highest mundane meditative attainments like the domain of neither perception nor non-perception. The Buddha says in that sutta that his disciple who is a sotapanna, like the leper Suppabuddha (Ud 5.3) has a knowledge that far surpasses all these meditation masters with such high meditative attainments.

The Buddha also alerts us in the therā sutta (AN 5.88) that:

Endowed with five attributes, O bhikkhus, an elder bhikkhu is one who has entered upon the path for the non-welfare of many people, for the unhappiness of many people, for the non-benefit of many people, for the suffering of devas and humans. With which five?

“An elder is one of long standing, one long gone forth. He is well known, a celebrity of householders and those gone forth, one who has a retinue of many people. He is a gainer of robes, almsfood, lodgings, medicines and provisions that are necessities for the sick. He is well-learned, bearer of what he has heard, one who accumulates what he has heard, those dhammas which are auspicious in the beginning, auspicious in the middle, auspicious in the end, with the correct meaning and phrasing, proclaiming the life of purity that is utterly complete and pure, such dhammas he has heard much of, borne in mind, recited verbally, accumulated, and carefully considered mentally. He has not penetrated [those dhammas] by view, being one of wrong view and distorted vision.

Having turned away many people from the true Dhamma, he causes to establish [them] in the untrue Dhamma. Seeing, truly is he, an elder bhikkhu of long standing, one long gone forth, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, a well-known elder bhikkhu, a celebrity of householders and those gone forth, one who has a retinue of many people, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, an elder bhikkhu who is a gainer of robes, almsfood, lodgings, medicines and provisions that are necessities for

the sick, they set about imitating him. Seeing, truly is he, a well-learned elder bhikkhu, a bearer of what he has heard, one who accumulates what he has heard, they set about imitating him.

Endowed with these five attributes, O bhikkhus, an elder bhikkhu is one who has entered upon the path for the non-welfare of many people, for the unhappiness of many people, for the non-benefit of many people, for the suffering of devas and humans.”

–AN 5.88

So we see that even the well-learned and famous elder bhikkhus of the Buddha’s time who have not made the breakthrough to the four noble truths and do not even possess the straightened view of a faith follower or a dhamma follower, lead their followers astray into what is not the true Dhamma, so what to speak about the sayadaws, the mahatheras, the ajahns and the lay meditation masters of later generations whose meditation techniques have become famous and garnered many followings?

Some may object that the reason the Buddha criticized these highly attained meditation masters in the brahmajālā sutta or highly learned elders in the therā sutta is that they did not practice vipassana meditation. But what is the vipassana that was discovered by the Buddha? Can modern meditation masters really teach their students to become endowed with the vipassana as taught by the Buddha?

The pāli word, “passana” or more commonly “dassana” is “vision”, and the “vi” prefix conveys distinct or penetrative. So vipassana is distinct vision or penetrative vision. But what is it a vision of? The Buddha defines it as the vision of dhammas in the samadhi sutta (AN 4.94) as, adhipaññadhammavipassanaya, which means the distinctive vision of dhammas with supreme wisdom (a sekha’s wisdom). The Buddha says in the mahāsalāyatanika sutta (MN 149) that both samatha and vipassana have to be brought into being (bhāvetabbā) with supreme knowledge (abhiññā), which from the mulapariyaya sutta (MN 1), is defined as a sekha’s knowledge. Adhipañña is also defined as a sekha’s wisdom in the sekha sutta (AN 3.85):

Then a certain bhikkhu visited with the Auspicious One.
Upon arrival, having bowed down to the Auspicious One,

he sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One: “A sekha, a sekha”, O Bhante, it is said. “To what extent, O Bhante, is one a sekha?”

“He trains,” O bhikkhu, therefore, he is called “a sekha.” And what does he train in? He trains in the higher virtue. He also trains in the higher states of mind. He also trains in the higher wisdom. “He trains,” O bhikkhu, therefore, he is called “a sekha.”

“For the sekha in training,
following along the straight path;
First comes the knowledge in extinction,
From that immediately there is final knowledge.

From that final-knowledge liberation,
indeed knowledge arises for the such-like one;
“unshakeable is my liberation,”
the fetter of being is extincted.”

–AN 3.85

To help clarify what vipassana is, the Buddha advises the bhikkhu seeking the endowment of vipassana to ask another bhikkhu who is endowed with vipassana the following questions in the samadhi sutta (AN 4.94):

- (1) How, O friend, should sankharas be seen (daṭṭhabbā)?
- (2) How should sankharas be touched (sammasitabbā)?
- (3) How should sankharas be seen distinctively (vipassitabbā)?

Now how the seeing of saṅkhāras or the distinctive seeing of saṅkhāras are only possible for the sekha is explained in the samudayadhamma sutta (SN 22.126):

Then a certain bhikkhu visited with the Auspicious One. Upon arrival, he bowed down to the Auspicious One and

sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One: “Ignorance, ignorance” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is ignorance? To what extent is one entrenched in ignorance?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-deaf puthujjana does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He does not wisely understand as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called ignorance. It is to this extent that one is entrenched in ignorance.”

When thus was said, that bhikkhu said this to the Auspicious One. “Noble knowledge, noble knowledge,” O Bhante, it is said. What, O Bhante, is noble knowledge? To what extent is one entrenched in noble knowledge?

“Here O Bhikkhu, the Dhamma-hearer, the noble disciple, wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise as form is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to vanish as form is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “form is of a nature to arise and vanish as form is of a nature to arise and vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be feeling..., perception..., sankharas..., “consciousness is of a nature to arise as consciousness is of a nature to arise.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to vanish as consciousness is of a nature to vanish.” He wisely understands as it has come to be “consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish as consciousness is of a nature to arise and vanish.” This, O Bhikkhu, is called noble knowledge. It is to this extent that one is entrenched in noble knowledge.”

–SN 22.126

As for how the touching of saṅkhāras is only possible for one who have distinctive knowledge of the deathless, the sekha, is explained in the following dhammapada verse:

yato yato sammāsati,
khandhānaṃ udayabbayaṃ.
labhatī pītipāmojjaṃ,
amataṃ taṃ vijānataṃ

From just the time he touches
the arising and vanishing of the khandhas
he attains joy and happiness,
that is his distinctive knowledge of the Deathless.

–Dhp 374

Note that jānāto passato is knowing and seeing as vijānāto vipas-sato is distinctive knowing and distinctive seeing. So vipassana is a wisdom faculty that the sekha is endowed with, with which he/she sees the impermanent nature of all sankharas. It is not a meditation technique.

Now many vipassana meditation masters claim that the breakthrough to the four noble truths is not necessary to possess this distinctive vision of the dhamma that the Buddha calls vipassana. Their traditions have taught them that contrary to what the Buddha says about vipassana in the suttas, vipassana is a technique that can be learned by experiencing impermanence through the senses. They teach that if one can experience impermanence in any of the six sense doors and just observe that experience or just make a mental note of that experience, then that is vipassana according to what has been passed down from a long line of teachers in their traditions. So here again it is important to clarify the type of impermanence experience that the Buddha taught as a path of purification.

The Buddha's teaching on impermanence can be divided into two categories, one which involves time (kālika) and one which is visible here and now (sanditṭhika), not involving time (akālika), inviting eye

witness (ehipassiko), leading onwards (opaneyyiko), to be personally experienced by the wise (paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhi).

Example of teachings on impermanence which involves time include suttas like the āneñja sutta (AN 3.116) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of the life span in the formless realms with the frequency on the order of tens of thousands of aeons; suttas like the sattasuriya sutta (AN 7.66) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of the world cycle with the frequency on the order of an aeon; suttas like the mahāsudassana sutta (DN 17) where the Buddha gives an example of the impermanence of a universal monarch with the frequency on the order of hundreds of thousands of years; or the assutavā sutta (SN 12.61), where the Buddha gives both an example of the impermanence of the body with the frequency on the order of about 100 years and an example of the impermanence of the mind with the frequency on the order of hours. Now there are even some vipassana meditation masters who claim that one can observe the impermanence of the mind or the body with a frequency on the order of millionth of a second, where within one second they can observe the mind or body arising and vanishing millions of times. But no matter how small a fraction of a second one can observe impermanence, it still involves time (kaliko). This kind of experiencing impermanence that involves time can be easily seen and understood by anyone, including puthujjanas, as the Buddha points out in the assutavā sutta. It is not the type of seeing of impermanence that leads to purification.

The Buddha teaches this kind of impermanence to let us know that no matter what time scales characterize the impermanence of these activities, whether extremely short like a millionth of a second, or extremely long like tens of thousands of aeons, they are all simply reckoned as unreliable, impermanent activities, which are called saṅkhārā in pāli. As he tells the venerable Ānanda at the end of the mahāsudassana sutta (DN 17), they are teachings that motivate us to make the breakthrough to the four noble truths in order to acquire the Dhamma-eye needed to put an end to all these saṅkhāras:

See O Ānanda, all those saṅkhāras have passed, ceased, degenerated. Thus is the impermanence, O Ānanda, of saṅkhāras. Thus is the non-lasting, O Ānanda, of saṅkhāras. Thus is the unreliability, O Ānanda, of saṅkhāras. With regard to all saṅkhāras, O Ānanda, just this much is enough

to attenuate them, enough to fade them away, enough to
be liberated from them.

–DN 17

The Buddha’s teaching on the seeing of impermanence that leads
to purification is summarized in the following dhammapada verse
(279):

sabbe saṅkhārā aniccā’ti,
yadā paññāya passati;
atha nibbindati dukkhe,
esa maggo visuddhiyā.

All saṅkhāras are impermanent,
when one sees this with wisdom,
one attenuates suffering.
This is the path of purification.

–Dhp 279

This seeing of impermanence that leads to purification is bearing
eye witness to the attenuation (nibbidha), the fading away (virāgā)
and the cessation (nirodhā) of the very activities of impermanence
(saṅkhārā). In other words, it is seeing the impermanent nature of the
very activity of impermanence itself, or arousing the pure and spotless
Dhamma-eye that sees: “Whatever is liable to origination, all that
is liable to cessation” as explained in the dhammacakkappavattana
sutta (SN 56.11). It is seeing the stilling of all activities involving time
(sabbasaṅkhārasamatho), no matter how long or short the frequency
of that activity is. It is also called “seeing paṭiccasamuppāda”, “seeing
the four noble truths” or “seeing the Dhamma”. Since this seeing
is visible here and now (sanditṭhiko), not involving time (akāliko),
inviting eye witness (ehipassiko), leading onwards (opaneyyiko), to
be personally experienced by the wise, one does not have to wait
for what is born to grow old, die and degenerate in order to see
its disappearance; one does not have to wait for a so-called mind-
moment in a millionth of a second in order to see the disappearance
of the body or the mind; one simply puts an end to contact (phassa)
to bear witness to the cessation of the very activity of impermanence
itself. This is concisely summarized by the Buddha in the following
verse concluding the mahāsudassana sutta (DN 17):

anicca vata sankhara
uppada vaya dhammino;
uppajjitva nirujjhanti
tesam vupasamo sukho.

Indeed, sankharas are impermanent
Arising and vanishing is their nature
Having arisen, they cease
Their stilling is happiness

–DN 17

So it is the experience of seeing the stilling of the arising and the vanishing activities of saṅkhāras that is the path of purification.

In the mahātanhasankhāyika sutta (MN 38), after questioning the bhikkhus on this kind of vision that sees paṭiccasamuppāda, the impermanence of all impermanent activities, the Buddha states:

Good, O bhikkhus. So you have been guided by me, O bhikkhus, with this Dhamma which is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onwards, to be personally experienced by the wise. For that which was said thus, O bhikkhus: This Dhamma is visible here and now, not involving time, inviting eye witness, leading onward, to be personally experienced by the wise, it was with reference to this that it was said.

–MN 38

So the breakthrough to the four noble truths is required to gain the Dhamma-eye necessary to see the impermanence of all impermanent activities. The problem with not first acquiring the Dhamma-eye to personally be an eye witness to the dhamma for oneself is that one becomes gullible to believe modern day meditation masters when they tell one that their method is a path of purification, and so just like the blind man who wears dirty and soiled garments thinking he is wearing clean white cloth in the Magandiya Sutta, one is not able to know and see for oneself that one has entered the path to purification but need to take it on faith in the meditation master.

Thus, unless one is at least a sotāpanna (minimum requirement for a sekha), one can think one is practicing vipassana all one wants but the fact of the matter is that one simply does not possess the Dhamma-eye by which one can distinguish what is vipassana from what is simply a misinterpretation of the suttas by their meditation masters.

A pre-requisite for the arising of the Dhamma-eye is the very starting point of wholesome dhammas, which the Buddha defines in the bhikkhu sutta (SN 47.3) as follows:

“Therefore, O bhikkhu, you should purify the very starting point of wholesome dhammas. And what is the starting point of wholesome dhammas? Virtue that is well purified and view that is straight.

–SN 47.3

The straightened view comes from learning the Dhamma through the proper explanations given in the suttas and not relying on other interpretations of the Dhamma. As stated in the Magandiya Sutta, association with sappurisa (true men) or kalyanamitta (good friend) in order to hear the saddhamma (true Dhamma) and practice in accordance with the saddhamma is the starting point of wholesome qualities in the Buddha’s teaching.

Although the Buddha’s teaching is widely available and easily accessible in many languages nowadays, the Buddha says in the Ap-pamada Sutta that the Dhamma is well proclaimed by him only for the one who has kalyanamitta and not the one without kalyanamitta. In fact he says the whole of the life of purity depends on a kalyanamitta, using himself as an example of a kalyanamitta.

In the dīghajāṇu sutta (AN 8.54), the Buddha defines kalyāṇamitta and describes the practice of virtue purification and view straightening:

And what, O Vyagghapajja, is noble friendship? Here, O Vyagghapajja, whatever village or town a clansman lives, he associates with heads of household or sons of heads of household there, whether young but fulfilled in virtue,

or old but fulfilled in virtue, those accomplished in faith, virtuous behavior, generosity, and wisdom. He converses with them and engages in discussions with them. Insofar as they are accomplished in faith, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in faith; insofar as they are accomplished in virtuous behavior, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in virtuous behavior; insofar as they are accomplished in generosity, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in generosity; insofar as they are accomplished in wisdom, he emulates them with respect to their accomplishment in wisdom. This, O Vyagghapajja, is called noble friendship.
–AN 8.54

And so the practice of virtue purification consists of one discussing virtue with those accomplished in virtue and emulating them with respect to their virtue accordingly until one's virtue conforms to theirs. Likewise, the practice of view straightening consists of one discussing faith, generosity and wisdom with those accomplished in faith, generosity and wisdom and emulating them with respect to their faith, generosity and wisdom accordingly until one's faith, generosity and wisdom conforms to theirs.

Unfortunately, nowadays, the word *kalyanamitta* has become current among disciples who stand in the faction of *puthujjana*. Any dhamma friend who inspires one to practice is looked upon as a *kalyanamitta*, since the *puthujjana* cannot distinguish what is proper practice from misguided practice or what is well-proclaimed from counterfeit interpretations of the Dhamma.

But as the Buddha clarifies in the *sallekha sutta* (MN 8) with the famous simile of one sinking in the mud, he explains that it is not possible for one sinking in the mud to help another who is sinking in the mud. Likewise in his teachings, it is not possible that one who is himself untamed, undisciplined, not attained *nibbāna*, can tame another, discipline another, or help another to attain *nibbāna*; but it is possible that one who is himself tamed, disciplined, attained *nibbāna*, can tame another, discipline another, and help another to attain *nibbāna*.

In the *bahujanahita sutta* (IT 84), the Buddha singles out three types of persons as *kalyanamitta* or *sappurisa* who arise in the world

for the welfare of many, for the happiness of many, out of compassion for the world, for the good, welfare, and happiness of devas and humans. They are a Buddha, an arahant and a sekha. Only these three types of persons have arrived at the saddhamma (true Dhamma) and can distinguish the saddhamma from the patirupaka dhamma (counterfeit dhamma). They are the only ones who are capable of explaining the well-proclaimed dhamma that is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end, with the right meaning and phrasing, and reveals the life of purity that is utterly perfect and pure. They have pulled themselves out of the mud and stand on firm ground unsullied by the mud. It is only they who understand the difficulties and subtleties involved in getting out of the mud and can therefore guide others out of the mud.

Given that nowadays true kalyāṇamittas are very rare, if one does not have access to a kalyāṇamitta, then one need to rely on saddhamma studies and discussions to understand the virtue and view of the noble ones and continuously emulate them with vigilance until one's virtue and view come in conformity with that of the noble ones. If one succeeds at this, then one has fulfilled the very starting point of wholesome dhammas.

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as foundation, if based on one's faith in the Buddha's awakening and one's faith in the Buddha's teachings on impermanence, one is resolved on realizing the Buddha's teachings on impermanence to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see kīṭāgiri sutta MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the khandhā sutta (SN 25.10):

“This is called a faith follower (saddhanusari), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the puthujjana. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell, or the animal womb or the sphere of ghost. He is definitely incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry.”

–SN 25.10

With virtue that is purified and view that has become straight as

foundation, if one submits to the Buddha's teaching on impermanence based on a measure of understanding with wisdom, and one is resolved on realizing these teachings to the extent that the five faculties have come to be (see *kīṭāgiri sutta* MN 70), the Buddha declares of such a one in the *khandhā sutta* (SN 25.10):

“This is called a dhamma follower (*dhammanusari*), one who has entered upon the fixed course of rightness, who has entered the plane of the true man, who has transcended the plane of the *puthujjana*. He is unable to do that deed which having done such a deed, he would be reborn in hell, or the animal womb, or the sphere of ghost. He is definitely incapable of passing away as long as he has not realized the fruit of stream entry.”
–SN 25.10

Both the *saddhānusārī* and *dhammānusārī* have entered upon the path to the realization of the fruit of stream-entry. By relying on the five faculties they have acquired, if they strive for the breakthrough to the four noble truths with vigilance and acquire the Dhamma-eye that knows and sees the Buddha's teaching on impermanence, the Buddha declares of such a one in the *khandhā sutta* (SN 25.10):

“This is called a stream enterer (*sotapanna*), not subject to the woeful plane, on a fixed course, destined for supreme awakening.”
–SN 25.10

This is how one becomes endowed with the distinct vision (*vipassana*) that sees the impermanence as taught by the Buddha, the unsurpassed surgeon, leading to purification.